

6. Drainage System

I. Ganga Drainage System

*The Himalayan Drainage System comprises the most famous river systems of India i.e. **the Indus, the Ganga and the Brahmaputra**. Most of these rivers are **perennial** in character, obtaining water from the glaciers, springs and rains.

*These rivers carve out a number of erosional landforms like **gorges, waterfalls and steep-sided valleys**, etc.

***Ganga** is the longest river (2525 km.) in India. The five confluences, known as the **Panch Prayag**, are all along the **Alaknanda**. They are, in downstream order, **Vishnuprayag** (Dhauliganga joins the Alaknanda), **Nandprayag** (where Nandakini joins Alaknanda), **Karnaprayag** (where Pindar joins Alaknanda), **Rudraprayag** (where Mandakini joins Alaknanda) and **Devprayag** (where Bhagirathi joins Alaknanda).

*The mainstream of Ganga begins at the confluence of Bhagirathi and Alaknanda in Devprayag. Ganga enters the plain area at Haridwar, flowing through the north of Rajmahal Hills, it finally enters Bangladesh by flowing through Farakka in West Bengal. In Bangladesh, it is known as the **Padma**. The Padma is joined by **Jamuna** (Brahmaputra). Further downstream, the Padma joins the **Meghna River**. Here onwards the whole river system is known as the **Meghna River system** which drains into the Bay of Bengal.

*The world's largest delta (**Ganga - Brahmaputra-Meghna Delta**) is formed between the Hugli river and the Meghna river.

*The important **left bank tributaries** of the Ganga are the **Ramganga, the Gomati, the Ghaghara, the Gandak, the Kosi and the Mahananda**.

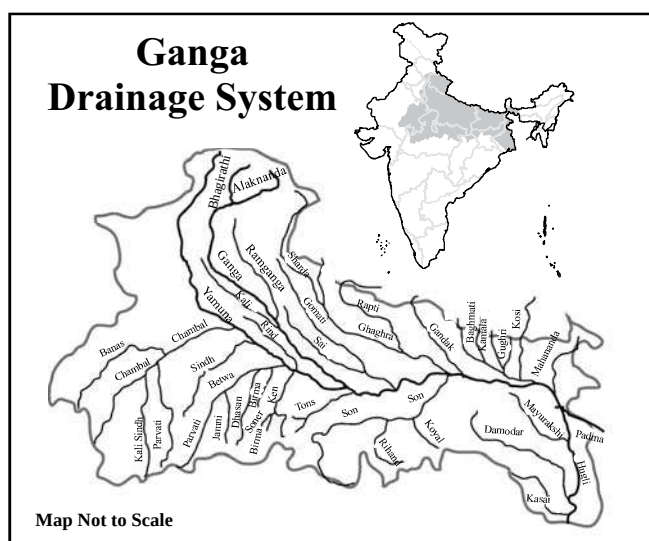
*The Yamuna is the right bank and the longest tributary of the Ganga. It has its source in the **Yamunotri Glacier** on the western slopes of the **Banderpunch Peak**. It joins the Ganga at **Prayag (Prayagraj)**.

***The Chambal, the Sindh, the Betwa and the Ken** are

the right bank tributaries of the Yamuna, while **the Tons, Hanuman Ganga and the Sasur Khaderi** are its left bank tributaries.

***The Chambal River** originates near **Dr. Ambedkar Nagar (Old Name - Mhow)** in the Malwa Plateau of Madhya Pradesh. It flows through a **gorge**. The Chambal is famous for its **badland topography**, which is called the **Chambal Ravines**. The **Gandak** originates from the Nepal Himalayas and joins the Ganga at **Sonpur** near Patna. The Ghaghara originates from the glacier of Mapchachungo. The river Sharda (Kali or Kali Ganga) joins it in the plain before it finally meeting Ganga at Revilganj (Saran, Bihar).

*The river **Ramganga** joins the Ganga near **Kannauj**. The river **Damodar** flows through a **rift valley** and finally joins the **Hugli**. The **Barakar** is its main tributary. The Damodar River is known as the '**Sorrow of Bengal**'. The **Mahananda** is the last left bank tributary of the Ganga joining it in West Bengal. *The Son is the major right bank tributary of Ganga. It originates in the Amarkantak Hill and joins the Ganga at near **Patna** (Bihar).



The antecedent rivers are those streams that originate prior to the uplift of the land surface of an upland or mountain but maintain their original course of flow even after the landmass is uplifted, by cutting through the uplifted landmass. The Ganga river is an example of an antecedent river. *The Alaknanda has its source in the Satopath glacier above Badrinath.